Himaayah Schools
MADRASAH

GUIDE

لَقَدْ كَانَ فِي قَصَصِهِمْ عِبْرَةٌ لِّأُولِي الْأَلْبَابِ

"There was certainly in their stories a lesson for those of understanding." (Yūsuf 12:111)

Stories of the Prophets

Twenty prophets of the Qur'an, from Ādam to Yaḥyā, as the Qur'an and the authentic Sunnah tell their stories.

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَٰنِ الرَّحِيمِ

Before you begin

> لَقَدْ كَانَ فِي قَصَصِهِمْ عِبْرَةٌ لِّأُولِي الْأَلْبَابِ
>
> **“There was certainly in their stories a lesson for those of understanding.”**
>
> Yūsuf 12:111.

Twenty-five prophets are named in the Qur’an. Our guide **Ūlu al-ʿAzm** tells the stories of the five greatest: Nūḥ, Ibrāhīm, Mūsā, ʿĪsā and Muḥammad ﷺ. This guide tells the stories of the other **twenty**, from Ādam, the first, to Yaḥyā, who lived in the time of ʿĪsā.

How this guide tells their stories

Every story is taken from the **Qur’an**, with the verses given, and from **authentic ḥadīth**. Many popular stories about the prophets come from the Isrāʾīliyyāt, reports from the People of the Book; where the Qur’an and Sunnah are silent, this guide is silent too.

For some prophets, such as Idrīs, Dhul-Kifl and al-Yasaʿ, Allah has told us very little. We believe in them as Allah has told us, without adding to it.

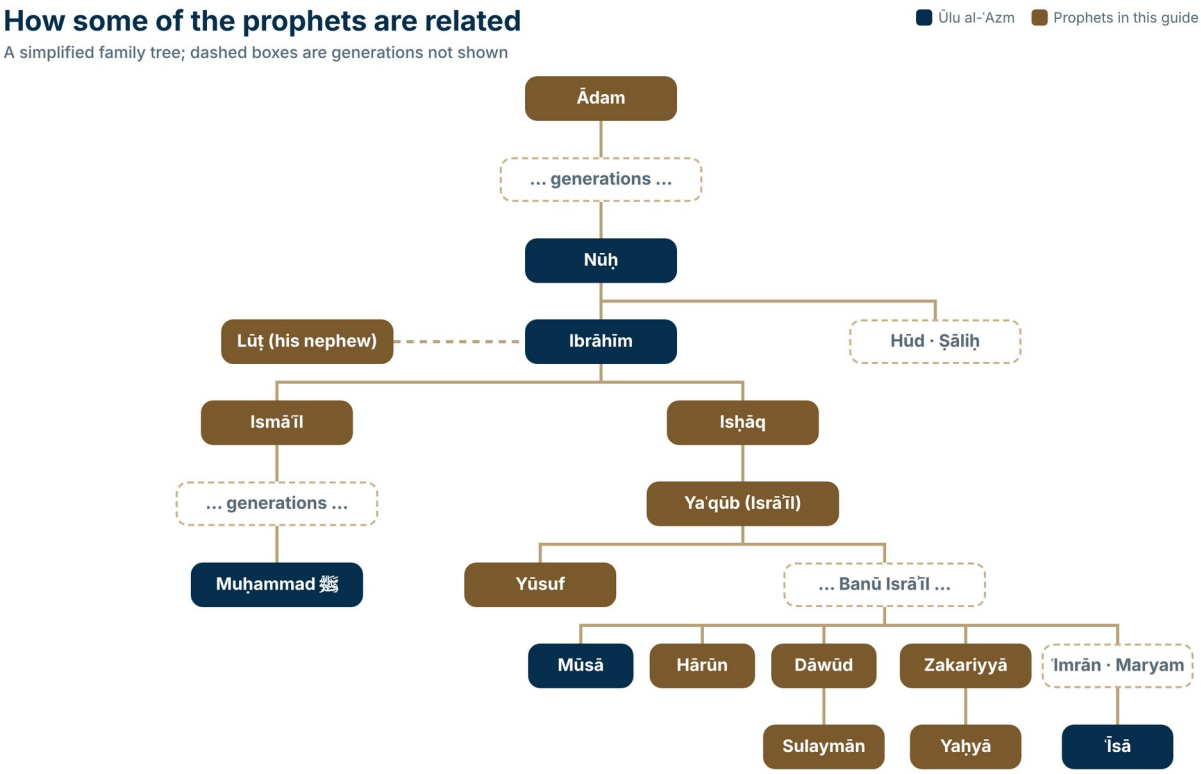
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The twenty prophets in this guide

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4	Ṣāliḥ	14	Dāwūd
5	Lūṭ	15	Sulaymān
6	Ismāʿīl	16	Ilyās
7	Isḥāq	17	Al-Yasaʿ
8	Yaʿqūb	18	Yūnus
9	Yūsuf	19	Zakariyyā
10	Shuʿayb	20	Yaḥyā

How some of the prophets are related

A simplified family tree; dashed boxes are generations not shown



Shuʿayb, Ayyūb, Yūnus, Ilyās, al-Yasaʿ, Idrīs and Dhul-Kifl are also prophets; their place in the family tree is not certain, so they are not shown.

1 · Ādam · The father of mankind and the first prophet

آدَمُ عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ

In the Qur’an: Al-Baqarah 2:30–38; al-Aʿrāf 7:11–25; Ṭā Hā 20:115–123

Allah created Ādam from clay with His own hands and breathed into him of the soul He created (Ṣād 38:71–72). He taught him the names of all things, then commanded the angels to prostrate to him in honour. All did, except Iblīs, who said in his pride: “I am better than him” (al-Aʿrāf 7:12). Ādam and his wife lived in Paradise and were told not to approach one tree. Shayṭān whispered to them, they ate from it, and they repented at once with the words Allah taught them: “Our Lord, we have wronged ourselves…” (7:23). Allah forgave them and sent them down to the earth, where Ādam became the first of the prophets. The Qur’an also tells of his two sons, one of whom killed the other out of envy (al-Māʾidah 5:27–31).

- Pride was the first sin committed against Allah: Iblīs’s refusal.
- When you slip, turn back to Allah quickly, as Ādam did.
- Envy can lead to the worst of crimes, as with the son of Ādam.

2 · Idrīs · A man of truth, raised to a high station

إِدْرِيسُ عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ

In the Qur’an: Maryam 19:56–57; al-Anbiyāʾ 21:85–86

Allah says: “And mention in the Book Idrīs. Indeed, he was a man of truth and a prophet. And We raised him to a high station” (19:56–57). He is counted among the patient (21:85). On the night of the Miʿrāj, the Prophet ﷺ met him in the fourth heaven, and he welcomed him as “the righteous brother and the righteous prophet” (al-Bukhārī 3207, Muslim 162). Little more is reported about him reliably, and we do not go beyond what Allah has told us.

- Truthfulness and patience raise a servant’s rank with Allah.
- Where the Qur’an and Sunnah are silent, we are silent.

3 · Hūd · Sent to the people of ʿĀd

هُودٌ عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ

In the Qur’an: Al-Aʿrāf 7:65–72; Hūd 11:50–60; ash-Shuʿarāʾ 26:123–140; al-Aḥqāf 46:21–26

ʿĀd lived in al-Aḥqāf, the sand dunes of southern Arabia. They were tall and strong, built monuments on every high place, and said: “Who is greater than us in strength?” (Fuṣṣilat 41:15). Hūd, one of their own, called them to worship Allah alone and to ask His forgiveness, promising rain and more strength. They mocked him and said their gods had struck him with madness. When they saw a cloud approaching, they rejoiced, saying it would bring rain; it was a furious wind that blew for seven nights and eight days and left them “like trunks of hollow palm trees” (al-Ḥāqqah 69:6–7). Allah saved Hūd and the believers.

- Strength and buildings do not protect a people from Allah.
- Istighfār brings rain and strength (Hūd 11:52).

4 · Ṣāliḥ · Sent to the people of Thamūd

صَالِحٌ عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ

In the Qur'an: Al-Aʿrāf 7:73–79; Hūd 11:61–68; ash-Shuʿarāʾ 26:141–159; ash-Shams 91:11–15

Thamūd lived after ʿĀd in the north of Arabia, carving their houses out of the mountains (al-Fajr 89:9). Ṣāliḥ called them to Allah, and they demanded a sign. Allah gave them a she-camel, with a day to drink from the well for her and a day for them (26:155), and warned them not to harm her. The most wretched of them hamstrung her (91:12–14). Ṣāliḥ told them: "Enjoy yourselves in your homes for three days" (11:65). Then the blast seized them and they lay dead in their homes. When the Prophet ﷺ passed their ruins at al-Ḥijr on the way to Tabūk, he told the Companions to pass by weeping (al-Bukhārī, 4419).

- A sign does not benefit a heart that is set on rejecting.
- Silence in the face of a great wrong can make a whole people share its punishment.

5 · Lūṭ · Nephew of Ibrāhīm, sent to the people of the cities

لُوطٌ عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ

In the Qur'an: Al-Aʿrāf 7:80–84; Hūd 11:77–83; al-Ḥijr 15:57–77; al-ʿAnkabūt 29:26–35

Lūṭ believed in Ibrāhīm and emigrated with him (al-ʿAnkabūt 29:26). He was sent to a people who committed an indecency no one in the world had done before them: approaching men instead of women, as well as robbing travellers (7:80–81; 29:29). They threatened to expel him for wanting to stay pure. Angels came to him in the form of handsome young men, and his people rushed to his house; the angels told him to leave by night with his family, except his wife, who was with the wrongdoers (11:81; at-Taḥrīm 66:10). At dawn the cities were turned upside down and stones of baked clay rained upon them.

- Keeping chaste and pure is part of the call of every prophet.
- Being related to a prophet saves no one without faith, as with Lūṭ's wife.

6 · Ismāʿīl · Son of Ibrāhīm, ancestor of the Prophet ﷺ

إِسْمَاعِيلُ عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ

In the Qur'an: Al-Baqarah 2:125–129; Maryam 19:54–55; aṣ-Ṣāffāt 37:100–107

Ibrāhīm left the infant Ismāʿīl and his mother Hājar in the empty valley of Makkah by Allah's command. Hājar ran seven times between aṣ-Ṣafā and al-Marwah looking for water, and Allah brought out the spring of Zamzam (al-Bukhārī, 3364). When Ismāʿīl was old enough to work with his father, Ibrāhīm saw in a dream that he was sacrificing him, and Ismāʿīl said: "O my father, do as you are commanded. You will find me, if Allah wills, of the patient" (37:102). Allah ransomed him with a

great sacrifice. Later father and son raised the foundations of the Kaʿbah together (2:127). Allah praised him as “true to his promise” (19:54). From his descendants came Muḥammad ﷺ.

- Obedience to Allah, even in the hardest command, is the way of the prophets.
- Righteous children are the fruit of righteous parents.

7 · Isḥāq · Son of Ibrāhīm and Sārah

إِسْحَاقُ عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ

In the Qur’an: Hūd 11:69–73; aṣ-Ṣāffāt 37:112–113; adh-Dhāriyāt 51:24–30

Angels came to Ibrāhīm as guests, and he hurried to bring them a roasted calf. They gave glad tidings to his aged wife Sārah of a son, Isḥāq, “and after Isḥāq, Yaʿqūb” (11:71). She laughed in wonder: “Shall I give birth while I am an old woman and this my husband is an old man?” (11:72). Isḥāq became a prophet among the righteous (37:112), and from him came Yaʿqūb and the prophets of the Children of Israel.

- Nothing is difficult for Allah: He gives children even in old age.
- Generosity to guests is the way of Ibrāhīm.

8 · Yaʿqūb · Isrāʾīl, the father of the twelve tribes

يَعْقُوبُ عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ

In the Qur’an: Al-Baqarah 2:132–133; Sūrat Yūsuf 12

Yaʿqūb, also called Isrāʾīl, was the son of Isḥāq. His twelve sons became the tribes of the Children of Israel. When his beloved son Yūsuf was taken from him by his brothers’ plot, he said: “Patience is most fitting (ṣabrun jamīl), and Allah is the one sought for help” (12:18). He wept until his eyes turned white with grief, yet said: “I only complain of my suffering and my grief to Allah” (12:86), and never lost hope (12:87). At his death he asked his sons: “What will you worship after me?” They said: “We will worship your God and the God of your fathers, Ibrāhīm, Ismāʿīl and Isḥāq, one God” (2:133).

- Beautiful patience: complain to Allah alone, and never despair of His mercy.
- Ask your children before you leave this world: what will you worship after me?

9 · Yūsuf · The best of stories

يُوسُفُ عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ

In the Qur’an: Sūrat Yūsuf 12

Allah calls his story “the best of stories” (12:3). As a boy he dreamed that eleven stars, the sun and the moon prostrated to him. His jealous brothers threw him into a well, and he was sold into slavery in Egypt. In the house of the ʿAzīz, his master’s wife tried to seduce him; he refused, saying “I seek refuge in Allah” (12:23), and chose prison over sin. In prison he called his companions to tawḥīd and

interpreted their dreams, and later the king's dream of seven fat and seven lean cows. He was made treasurer of Egypt, saved the land from famine, and when his brothers came for food he forgave them: "No blame upon you today" (12:92). His parents and brothers came to Egypt and bowed before him, and his childhood dream came true (12:100).

- Chastity and fear of Allah are worth more than freedom.
- Allah's plan works through hardship: the well and the prison led to the throne.
- Forgive those who wronged you when you are able to punish them.

10 · Shuʿayb · Sent to Madyan

شُعَيْبٌ عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ

In the Qur'an: Al-Aʿrāf 7:85–93; Hūd 11:84–95; ash-Shuʿarāʾ 26:176–191

Shuʿayb was sent to the people of Madyan, traders who cheated in their measures and weights, blocked the roads and spread corruption. He called them to worship Allah and give full measure, saying: "I only intend reform as much as I am able. My success is only through Allah" (11:88). They mocked him: "Does your prayer command you that we leave what our fathers worshipped, or stop doing what we like with our wealth?" (11:87). They threatened to stone him, and were destroyed by the blast and the earthquake (11:94; 7:91).

- Honesty in trade is part of the religion.
- Islām guides how we earn and spend, not only how we pray.

11 · Ayyūb · The model of patience

أَيُّوبُ عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ

In the Qur'an: Al-Anbiyāʾ 21:83–84; Ṣād 38:41–44

Ayyūb was tested with severe illness and the loss of his wealth and children, for a long time. He did not complain except to Allah, calling: "Indeed, harm has touched me, and You are the most merciful of the merciful" (21:83). Allah answered him: "Strike the ground with your foot; this is a cool spring for washing and drinking" (38:42). He was healed, and Allah gave him back his family and as many again with them. Allah praised him: "Indeed, We found him patient. What an excellent servant! Indeed, he constantly turned back to Allah" (38:44).

- Patience is not silence about pain, but complaining only to Allah.
- After long hardship, relief comes from Allah.

12 · Dhul-Kifl · Among the patient and the best

ذُو الْكِفْلِ عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ

In the Qur'an: Al-Anbiyāʾ 21:85–86; Ṣād 38:48

Allah mentions Dhul-Kifl with Ismāʿīl and Idrīs: “All were of the patient. And We admitted them into Our mercy. Indeed, they were of the righteous” (21:85–86), and counts him “among the best” (38:48). Most scholars hold that he was a prophet. Nothing more is reported about him reliably, and we believe in him as Allah has told us.

- Allah honours servants we know little about: what matters is being known to Allah.

13 · Hārūn · Brother and minister of Mūsā

هَارُونُ عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ

In the Qur’an: Ṭā Hā 20:29–36, 20:85–94; al-Qaṣaṣ 28:34–35

When Allah sent Mūsā to Pharaoh, Mūsā asked for his brother Hārūn as a helper: “He is more eloquent than me in speech, so send him with me as a support” (28:34). Allah granted it, and Hārūn became a prophet and Mūsā’s minister. While Mūsā was away for forty nights, as-Sāmirī led the Children of Israel to worship a golden calf. Hārūn warned them: “O my people, you are only being tested by it, and indeed your Lord is the Most Merciful, so follow me” (20:90). When Mūsā returned in anger and seized him by the beard, Hārūn said: “O son of my mother, do not seize me by my beard” (20:94), explaining that he feared dividing the people. The Prophet ﷺ told ʿAlī: “You are to me as Hārūn was to Mūsā, except that there is no prophet after me” (al-Bukhārī 3706, Muslim 2404).

- Good helpers are a blessing: ask Allah for righteous companions.
- Gentleness and wisdom in calling to the truth, even when people go astray.

14 · Dāwūd · King and prophet, given the Zabūr

دَاوُودُ عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ

In the Qur’an: Al-Baqarah 2:251; Saba’ 34:10–11; Ṣād 38:17–26

As a young man in the army of Ṭālūt, Dāwūd killed the giant Jālūt, and Allah gave him kingship and wisdom (2:251). He was given the Zabūr (an-Nisāʾ 4:163). The mountains and the birds glorified Allah with him (38:18–19), and Allah made iron soft in his hands so that he made coats of mail (34:10–11). He judged between people, and when two disputants climbed into his prayer room, he realised he had been tested and sought forgiveness (38:21–25). The Prophet ﷺ said: “The most beloved prayer to Allah is the prayer of Dāwūd, and the most beloved fasting is the fasting of Dāwūd: he slept half the night, stood a third and slept a sixth, and fasted every other day” (al-Bukhārī 1131, Muslim 1159). And “Dāwūd used to eat only from the work of his own hands” (al-Bukhārī, 2073).

- Power and kingship did not distract him from worship.
- Eat from the work of your own hands.

15 · Sulaymān · The king who understood the birds

سُلَيْمَانُ عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ

In the Qur'an: An-Naml 27:15–44; Sabaʾ 34:12–14; Ṣād 38:30–40

Sulaymān inherited Dāwūd's prophethood and kingship. He was taught the speech of birds, and the wind and the jinn were made subject to him (27:16; 34:12). Marching with his army, he heard an ant warn the others to get out of the way, and he smiled and prayed: "My Lord, enable me to be grateful for Your favour…" (27:19). The hoopoe brought him news of the Queen of Sabaʾ, who worshipped the sun. He wrote to her, "In the name of Allah, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate", inviting her to Islām; her throne was brought to him in the blink of an eye, and she said: "I submit with Sulaymān to Allah, Lord of the worlds" (27:44). He died leaning on his staff, and the jinn did not know until a creature of the earth ate through it (34:14), showing that the jinn do not know the unseen.

- Gratitude for blessings, even in great power.
- The jinn and fortune-tellers do not know the unseen.

16 · Ilyās · Sent to a people who worshipped Baʿl

إِلْيَاسُ عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ

In the Qur'an: Al-Anʿām 6:85; aṣ-Ṣāffāt 37:123–132

Ilyās said to his people: "Will you not fear Allah? Do you call upon Baʿl and leave the best of creators, Allah, your Lord and the Lord of your forefathers?" (37:124–126). They denied him, and Allah said: "Peace be upon Ilyās. Indeed, he was of Our believing servants" (37:130–132).

- Every prophet called people away from idols to Allah alone.

17 · Al-Yasaʿ · Among the best

الْيَسَعُ عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ

In the Qur'an: Al-Anʿām 6:86; Ṣād 38:48

Allah mentions al-Yasaʿ among the prophets He favoured above the worlds (6:86) and "among the best" (38:48). Nothing more is reported about him reliably.

- Believing in all the prophets, those we know much about and those we know little about, is part of īmān.

18 · Yūnus · The companion of the whale

يُونُسُ عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ

In the Qur'an: Yūnus 10:98; al-Anbiyāʾ 21:87–88; aṣ-Ṣāffāt 37:139–148; al-Qalam 68:48–50

Yūnus was sent to a people of more than a hundred thousand (37:147). When they refused, he left them in anger, before Allah permitted him (21:87). He boarded a ship; it was overloaded, lots were cast, and he was thrown into the sea and swallowed by a great fish. In the darkness he called: "There is no god but You. Glory be to You. Indeed, I have been of the wrongdoers" (21:87). Allah

saved him and cast him onto the shore, ill, and made a gourd plant grow over him. Meanwhile his people repented when they saw the punishment approaching, and Allah accepted it: the only people in the Qur'an whose faith at that moment benefited them (10:98). The Prophet ﷺ said: "Do not say that I am better than Yūnus ibn Mattā" (al-Bukhārī, 3395).

- No darkness is too deep for duʿāʾ.
- Patience with people, and waiting for Allah's command.

19 · Zakariyyā · Guardian of Maryam, father of Yaḥyā

زَكَرِيَّا عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ

In the Qur'an: Āl ʿImrān 3:37–41; Maryam 19:2–11; al-Anbiyāʾ 21:89–90

Zakariyyā was a carpenter (Muslim, 2379) and took care of Maryam in the temple. Whenever he entered her prayer room he found food with her, and she said: "It is from Allah" (3:37). Moved, old and with a barren wife, he called on his Lord secretly for a child (19:3–6). Allah gave him glad tidings of Yaḥyā, and as a sign he could not speak to people for three nights except by gestures, though he could remember Allah (19:10–11). Allah said of him and his family: "They used to hasten to good deeds and call on Us in hope and fear, and they were humble before Us" (21:90).

- Never stop asking Allah, however unlikely it seems.
- A secret duʿāʾ in the night is beloved to Allah.

20 · Yaḥyā · Given wisdom as a child

يَحْيَىٰ عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ

In the Qur'an: Āl ʿImrān 3:39; Maryam 19:12–15

Allah gave Yaḥyā wisdom while still a child, with tenderness and purity. He was devoted, kind to his parents, and neither arrogant nor disobedient (19:12–14). He confirmed the word from Allah, ʿĪsā, and was a leader, chaste, and a prophet among the righteous (3:39). "Peace be upon him the day he was born, the day he dies and the day he is raised alive" (19:15). On the Miʿrāj, the Prophet ﷺ met him with ʿĪsā, his cousin, in the second heaven (al-Bukhārī 3207, Muslim 162).

- Youth is the best time to begin worship and seeking knowledge.
- Kindness to parents is a mark of the prophets.

Test Self-test

Choose the best answer. The answers follow the questions.

1. **Who refused to prostrate to Ādam?**
   a) Iblīs b) Jibrīl c) Mīkāʾīl d) Qābīl

2. **Which people were destroyed by a wind of seven nights and eight days?**
   a) Thamūd b) Madyan c) ʿĀd d) The people of Lūṭ

3. **The sign given to Thamūd was:**
   a) A staff b) A she-camel c) A flood d) A ship

4. **Who said "O my father, do as you are commanded"?**
   a) Ismāʿīl b) Isḥāq c) Yūsuf d) Yaḥyā

5. **"Ṣabrun jamīl" (beautiful patience) was said by:**
   a) Ayyūb b) Yaʿqūb c) Yūnus d) Shuʿayb

6. **Which prophet's story does Allah call "the best of stories"?**
   a) Mūsā b) Sulaymān c) Dāwūd d) Yūsuf

7. **Shuʿayb's people were known for:**
   a) Cheating in weights and measures b) Carving houses in mountains c) Worshipping the sun d) Building towers

8. **Who was given the Zabūr?**
   a) Sulaymān b) Dāwūd c) Hārūn d) Zakariyyā

9. **Who heard an ant speak and smiled?**
   a) Dāwūd b) Yūsuf c) Sulaymān d) Hūd

10. **Whose people repented when they saw the punishment coming, and were saved?**
    a) Yūnus b) Ṣāliḥ c) Lūṭ d) Hūd

11. **Zakariyyā worked as a:**
    a) Shepherd b) Trader c) Blacksmith d) Carpenter

12. **How many prophets are named in the Qur'an?**
    a) 20 b) 25 c) 30 d) 313

No.	Answer	No.	Answer
1	a) Iblīs	7	a) Cheating in weights
2	c) ʿĀd	8	b) Dāwūd
3	b) A she-camel	9	c) Sulaymān
4	a) Ismāʿīl	10	a) Yūnus
5	b) Yaʿqūb	11	d) Carpenter
6	d) Yūsuf	12	b) 25

For further study

- Our guide **Ūlu al-ʿAzm**, on Nūḥ, Ibrāhīm, Mūsā, ʿĪsā and Muḥammad ﷺ.
- **Qaṣaṣ al-Anbiyāʾ** (Stories of the Prophets), Ibn Kathīr, read with a teacher.
- Sūrat Yūsuf, Sūrat al-Anbiyāʾ and Sūrat Ṣād, each in one sitting with a translation.

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وَمَا تَوْفِيقِي إِلَّا بِاللَّهِ

"And my success is only through Allah." (Hūd 11:88)

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Twenty prophets, one message.

This book from the Himaayah Madrasah tells the stories of the prophets named in the Qur'an besides Ūlu al-ʿAzm, with the verses for every event and the lessons for us.

- Ādam, Idrīs, Hūd, Ṣāliḥ and Lūṭ
- Ismāʿīl, Isḥāq, Yaʿqūb and Yūsuf
- Shuʿayb, Ayyūb, Dhul-Kifl and Hārūn
- Dāwūd, Sulaymān, Ilyās, al-Yasaʿ, Yūnus, Zakariyyā and Yaḥyā
- A family tree, lessons and a self-test

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